Topic 15 — Archaeology (पुरातत्व)

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Archaeology | Archaeological Discoveries | Excavations | Ancient Sites

Sources: NCERT Themes I, ASI, UPPCS Prelims 2018–2025 **Last verified:** August 2026

Current Affairs

- In **2025–26** ASI (पुरातत्व सर्वेक्षण) dug Rakhigarhi (राखीगढ़ी) Mound 7. Burials went to **AnSI Kolkata**. aDNA samples went to **BSIP Lucknow (लखनऊ)**. The site remains in **Haryana**, not Uttar Pradesh (उत्तर प्रदेश).
- **Sarnath** (सारनाथ) was inscribed as a UNESCO World Heritage (विश्व धरोहर) site in **2026**.

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15.1 Archaeology

Archaeology studies past humans from the things they left. Dig, date, and read the context. It is not the same as a history textbook.

- Archaeology rebuilds life from pottery, bone, brick, seal, coin (मुद्रा) and inscription. It is essential where the script (लिपि) is unread, as at Harappa.
- **History** reads texts. Archaeology reads layers. Both are needed after the Mauryas.
- **Stratigraphy** follows the law of superposition. In an undisturbed trench the **lower layer is older**.
- **Typology** dates by shape. A pot type or seal style is matched across mounds before a lab date exists.
- **Radiocarbon (C-14)** dates **organic** carbon: charcoal, bone, wood, seed. It does **not** date a stone seal or a copper tool by itself.
- **Thermoluminescence (TL) dating** is employed specifically to date crystalline materials subjected to heat, making it the primary method for dating ancient pottery, terracotta figurines, and fired brick.
- **Pollen analysis** reconstructs crop and climate. It does not date a metal hoard.
- **Epigraphy** reads inscriptions. **Numismatics** reads coins (रूपक). Both are archaeological source-types, not separate ministries.
- Field archaeology is survey, trench and record. Underwater work is a branch. **Dwarka** (द्वारका) and **Poompuhar** are the named marine cases.
- **ASI** was set up in **1861. Alexander Cunningham** was the first Director General. It sits under **Culture**.
- Digging a protected mound needs an ASI or state licence under the **AMASR Act, 1958**.
- The **Antiquities and Art Treasures Act, 1972** criminalises illicit export. Treasure hunting that wrecks layers is not archaeology.

- **GPR** and **LiDAR** map buried walls before a spade goes in.
- **Narmada (नर्मदा) / Hathnora** yielded a hominin fossil. **Arun Sonakia (1982)** is the named finder. It is palaeoanthropology, not an IVC (नगरीय) city.

> **Logic:** C-14 needs organic carbon**. A statement that C-14 dates Harappan stone seals is false.

15.2 Archaeological Discoveries

A discovery card is who recognised the mound, in which year, and what changed in the textbook.

- Discovery is not the same as a full excavation. Cunningham saw a **Harappan seal in 1853**. He did not yet name a civilisation.
- **Daya Ram Sahni** opened **Harappa in 1921**. Do not give him Mohenjo-daro.
- **R. D. Banerji** opened **Mohenjo-daro in 1922**. Do not give him Harappa.
- **John Marshall** announced the Indus civilisation to the world in **1924**. Large ASI clearance at Mohenjo-daro ran into **1931**.
- **Mortimer Wheeler** re-dug **Harappa in 1946** with a measured grid. He is not the first IVC excavator.
- **Mehrgarh** (मेहरगढ़) in Balochistan is the Neolithic farming precursor. It is not an Indian state site.
- Archaeologist **Dr. V. S. Wakankar** discovered the prehistoric rock shelters and paintings of **Bhimbetka** (Raisen district, Madhya Pradesh) in **1957**, establishing their Upper Palaeolithic and Mesolithic antiquity. He is distinct from H. D. Sankalia (सांकलिया), M. S. Vats, or V. N. Mishra.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2020, Q10

Which of the following Indian Archaeologists first visited 'Bhimbetka Caves' and discovered prehistoric significance of its rock paintings?

A. Madho Swaroop Vatsa (वत्स) B. H. D. Sankalia C. V. S. Wakankar D. V. N. Mishra

Show answer

Ans: C — V. S. Wakankar. 1957. MP rock shelters, not Harappan.

- **Bruce Foote** found India's first palaeolith at **Pallavaram (1863)**.
- **James Prinsep** deciphered **Brahmi (ब्राह्मी) in 1837**. That unlocked Ashokan edicts. It is epigraphy, not an IVC dig.
- Cunningham surveyed **Sarnath in 1835–36**. The **Lion (सिंह) Capital** itself was recovered by **F. O. Oertel in 1904–05**. Do not date the emblem find to 1835.
- **Ajanta** (अजंता) was rediscovered in **1819** by **John Smith (स्मिथ)**, a British officer.
- **Nalanda** (नालंदा) was noted by early surveyors. ASI clearance in the twentieth century exposed the mahavihara (महाविहार). UNESCO WHS (यूनेस्को) year is **2016**.
- **S. R. Rao** is the Lothal and later Dwarka name.
- **R. S. Bisht** is the Dholavira name. UNESCO WHS year is **2021**.
- **B. B. Lal** dug **Kalibangan**, **Hastinapur** and **Ahichhatra**.

- **Sanauli** (Baghpat, **UP**) produced chariot burials in **2018**. The culture tag is late Harappan / **OCP**. It is not Alamgirpur and not the eastern boundary.
- **Keeladi / Keezhadi** (Tamil Nadu, Vaigai) is a Sangam-era urban (नगरीय) excavation from **2014** onward.

> **Logic:** Sahni = Harappa 1921. Banerji = Mohenjo-daro 1922. Wakankar = Bhimbetka**.

15.3 Excavations

Excavation is controlled digging that keeps context. Vertical cuts read time. Horizontal cuts read the plan.

- An artefact without its layer is a souvenir. Context is the date and the function.
- A **vertical** trench is cut to read **chronology**. Deep Harappan citadel (दुर्ग) sections are the type case.
- A **horizontal** exposure maps **one period's** streets and houses. Mohenjo-daro's grid is the type case.
- **Wheeler's box-grid** divides the mound into squares. **Balks** (earth walls) are left so the layers can still be read.
- Marshall's earlier IVC work was broader clearance. Wheeler added measured stratigraphy. Wheeler did **not** discover Harappa.
- Sequence on a licensed dig: survey → permission → grid and datum → layer-by-layer lift → sieve → draw and photograph → conserve → publish.
- **Rescue / salvage** excavation records a mound before a dam (बांध) or highway removes it.
- Conservation challenges include rising water tables that decompose baked brick, while modern habitation overlaying ancient mounds at **Rakhigarhi** and **Hastinapur** poses severe encroachment challenges.
- **H. D. Sankalia** is the Deccan (दक्कन) Chalcolithic (ताम्रपाषाण) name. **Nevasa** and **Inamgaon** are his sites.
- Underwater excavation is still excavation. It is not a third dating method.

> **Logic:** Vertical = time. Horizontal = space. Wheeler = grid**, not first IVC spade.

15.4 Ancient Sites

For each site, learn the period, the state, and one speciality. Watch sites that are not in Uttar Pradesh.

Prehistoric (2023 match set)

- **Nevasa** is in **Maharashtra**.
- **Isampur** is an Acheulian (ऐशूलियन) quarry in **Karnataka** (Hunsgi–Baichbal).
- **Didwana** is in **Rajasthan** (Thar (थार) palaeolithic).
- **Gudiyam Cave** is in **Tamil Nadu**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q27

Match List-I with List-II and choose the correct answer using the code given below.

List-I (Archaeological Site) A. Nevasa B. Isampur C. Didwana D. Gudiyam Cave

List-II (Present Location) 1. Rajasthan 2. Tamil Nadu 3. Maharashtra 4. Karnataka

A. A-3, B-4, C-1, D-2 B. A-4, B-3, C-1, D-2 C. A-3, B-4, C-2, D-1 D. A-3, B-2, C-4, D-1

Show answer

Ans: A. Nevasa–MH, Isampur–KA, Didwana–RJ, Gudiyam–TN.

- **Bhimbetka** is **MP**. Palaeolithic to historic paint layers. UNESCO WHS **2003**.
- **Adamgarh** is **MP** Mesolithic.
- **Burzahom** (बुरज़होम) is **J&K** Neolithic pit-dwellings.
- **Belan valley** (Koldihwa, Mahagara, Chopani Mando) is the **UP** Neolithic–Mesolithic belt.
- **Sarai Nahar Rai** and **Mahadaha** are **UP** Mesolithic.

Harappan / IVC

- **Harappa** (Sahiwal district, Pakistani Punjab): Excavated by Daya Ram Sahni in 1921; noted for its Great Granary, citadel, and cemetery R-37 (आर-37).
- **Mohenjo-daro** is in **Sindh**. Great Bath and planned streets. Banerji 1922 (बनर्जी). Boat models occur here.
- **Dholavira** is in **Kutch, Gujarat**. Reservoirs, stadium, signboard. WHS **2021**.
- **Lothal** (Gulf of Khambhat, Gujarat): Excavated by S. R. Rao; featuring a tidal dockyard, bead-making factory (फैक्टरी), fire altars, and terracotta boat models.
- **Kalibangan** is in **Rajasthan**. Fire altars and a ploughed field. **B. B. Lal**.
- **Rakhigarhi** is in **Hisar, Haryana**. It is India's **largest** IVC site. It is **not** in UP.
- **Banawali** is in **Haryana**.
- **Balu** is in **Haryana**.
- **Padri** is in **Gujarat**.
- **Manda** is in **Jammu & Kashmir**. It marks the **northern** edge, not the east.
- **Surkotada** is in Gujarat. Horse-bone debate.
- **Chanhudaro** (चन्हूदड़ो) (Sindh, Pakistan): Specialized craft and bead manufacturing centre without a fortified citadel; excavated by N. G. Majumdar and Ernest Mackay.
- **Alamgirpur** is in **Meerut, Uttar Pradesh. It marks the** eastern** boundary.
- **Mandi** is in **Uttar Pradesh** (उत्तर प्रदेश).
- **Hulas** is in **Saharanpur, Uttar Pradesh.
- **Santhali** is in **Bijnor, Uttar Pradesh.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q87

Which of the following archaeological sites related to the Indus Valley Civilization are situated in present-day Uttar Pradesh?

1. Mandi
2. Rakhigarhi
3. Hulas

A. 1 and 2 B. Only 3 C. 1 and 3 D. Only 1

Show answer

Ans: C — 1 and 3. Mandi and Hulas = UP. **Rakhigarhi = Haryana**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q28

The eastern boundary of the Harappan culture is indicated by which of the following?

A. Harappa B. Alamgirpur C. Rakhigarhi D. Manda

Show answer

Ans: B — Alamgirpur (Meerut, UP). Manda = north (J&K). Rakhigarhi = Haryana.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q68

From which archaeological site of the Indus Valley Civilization are figures or models of boats found?

A. Dholavira and Bhagatrav B. Harappa and Kot Diji C. Mohenjo-daro and Lothal D. Kalibangan and Ropar

Show answer

Ans: C — Mohenjo-daro and Lothal.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2021, Q100

In which State of India is the Harappan Civilization site Mandi situated?

A. Gujarat B. Haryana C. Rajasthan D. Uttar Pradesh

Show answer

Ans: D — Uttar Pradesh.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2020, Q12

Match List-I with List-II and answer using the codes given below the lists:

List-I (Harappan Site) A. Balu B. Manda C. Padri D. Hulas

List-II (UT/State of India) 1. Uttar Pradesh 2. Jammu & Kashmir 3. Haryana 4. Gujarat

A. 3 2 1 4 B. 2 3 4 1 C. 2 4 3 1 D. 3 2 4 1

Show answer

Ans: D. Balu–Haryana, Manda–J&K, Padri–Gujarat, Hulas–UP.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q88

Which of the following centres related to Indus Valley are situated in Uttar Pradesh?

I. Kalibanga II. Lothal III. Alamgirpur IV. Hulas

A. I, II, III, IV B. I, II C. II, III D. III, IV

Show answer

Ans: D — III and IV. Kalibangan = Rajasthan. Lothal = Gujarat.

Chalcolithic and early historic (UP extra)

- **Sanauli** is **Baghpat, Uttar Pradesh. 2018 chariot burial. Late Harappan / OCP. Not the 2025 Mandi–Hulas pair.
- **Inamgaon** and **Kayatha** and **Ahar** are Deccan / MP / Rajasthan Chalcolithic. Not UP IVC.
- **Hastinapur**, **Kaushambi**, **Ahichhatra** and **Shravasti** are **UP** early-historic mounds. **B. B. Lal** is the Hastinapur name.
- **Sarnath** is **Uttar Pradesh. First-sermon Buddhist site. Lion Capital. WHS** 2026**.
- **Pataliputra** (पाटलिपुत्र) is Bihar. **Nalanda** is Bihar. **Sanchi** (सांची) is MP. **Ajanta** and **Ellora** (एलोरा) are Maharashtra.
- **Fatehpur Sikri** (फतेहपुर सीकरी) is UP medieval urban archaeology. **Hampi** (हम्पी) is Karnataka.

> **Logic:** Mandi + Hulas + Alamgirpur = UP. Rakhigarhi = Haryana. Eastern edge = Alamgirpur**, not Manda.
